Priority 5. Secure the Indian Ocean

As India becomes more integrated with the world, the role of the Indian Ocean assumes greater importance. [22] The ocean is a valuable conduit for global trade, including commercial shipping and especially energy, with significant amounts of the world's oil supply transported through its chokepoints. Its littoral is also densely populated, home to some two billion people. But while the Indian Ocean region links some of the fastest growing areas of the world—Southeast Asia, South Asia, and East Africa—it is also vulnerable to natural disasters. The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami killed over 2,00,000 people and Cyclone Nargis is believed to have killed over 1,00,000 people in Myanmar in 2008. The ocean is naturally vital to Indian interests: most of India's trade by volume and a majority of its trade by value comes via the Indian Ocean. [23] Beyond that, the Indian Ocean plays a vital role as a source of fishing and mineral resources.

Apart from its growing importance, the Indian Ocean is distinguished by its politics. It has historically been less contested than the Pacific, and while relatively under-governed it is also more open. This inclusivity is reflected in India's vision for the Indian Ocean as laid out in a speech delivered by Modi in Mauritius in 2015. [24] The looser but more collaborative nature of governance in the Indian Ocean has presented complications in addressing issues such as piracy, which peaked in the Indian Ocean between 2005 and 2010 and cost the global shipping industry about $6 billion per year. [25] Countering piracy off the Somali coast and in the Gulf of Aden required naval operations by several countries, including India, and resulted in a drop in incidents after 2012. But another participant in counter-piracy operations during this period was China. And it was Beijing's entry into the Indian Ocean that began to generate renewed concerns about rising security competition.

China's activity in the Indian Ocean has generally assumed two forms. The first involves investments in infrastructure in several Indian Ocean countries. For example, many nominally civilian ports in the Indian Ocean littoral are of important strategic value and could conceivably be adapted to